Persuasive Technology Strategies and Instagram

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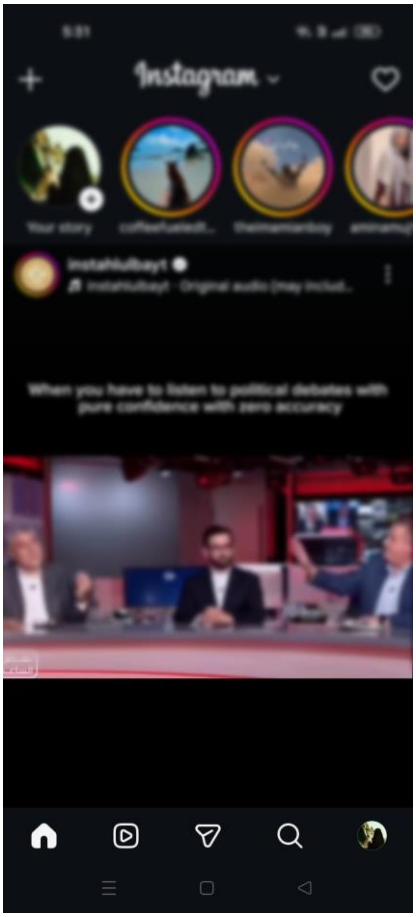
Dr. Shuaib Karim

1. Reduction:

This strategy said that to persuade the user for a task ,make it easy for them by reducing the complexity to perform that task i.e. minimizing the cost, maximizing the gains.

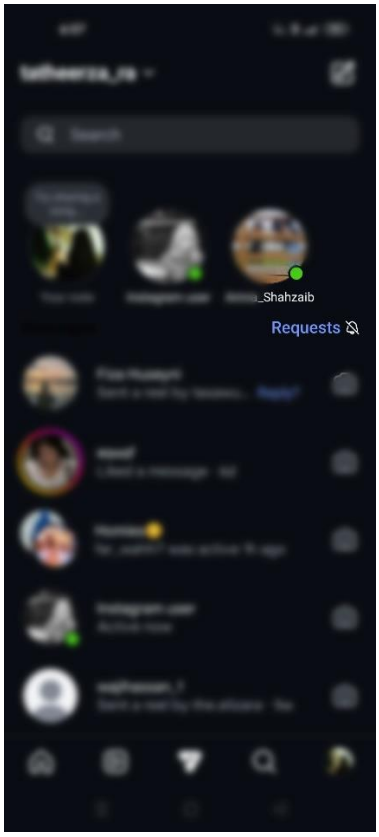
In context of Instagram:

The homepage appears with all the tabs icons which means you can access every other tab directly from the homepage.



The top ribbon with + sign for post/reel creation, heart sign for notifications .The lower ribbon with Home page, Reels, messaging ,trending and profile section tabs icon.

A particular e.g. of reduction observed is the notification symbol in the message tab. For example, you didn't allow Instagram to send you notifications so there's a small bell icon in message tab .If you messaged someone and want to be notified whenever they replied so you can allow the notifications right there no need to navigate to app settings for allowing the notifications.

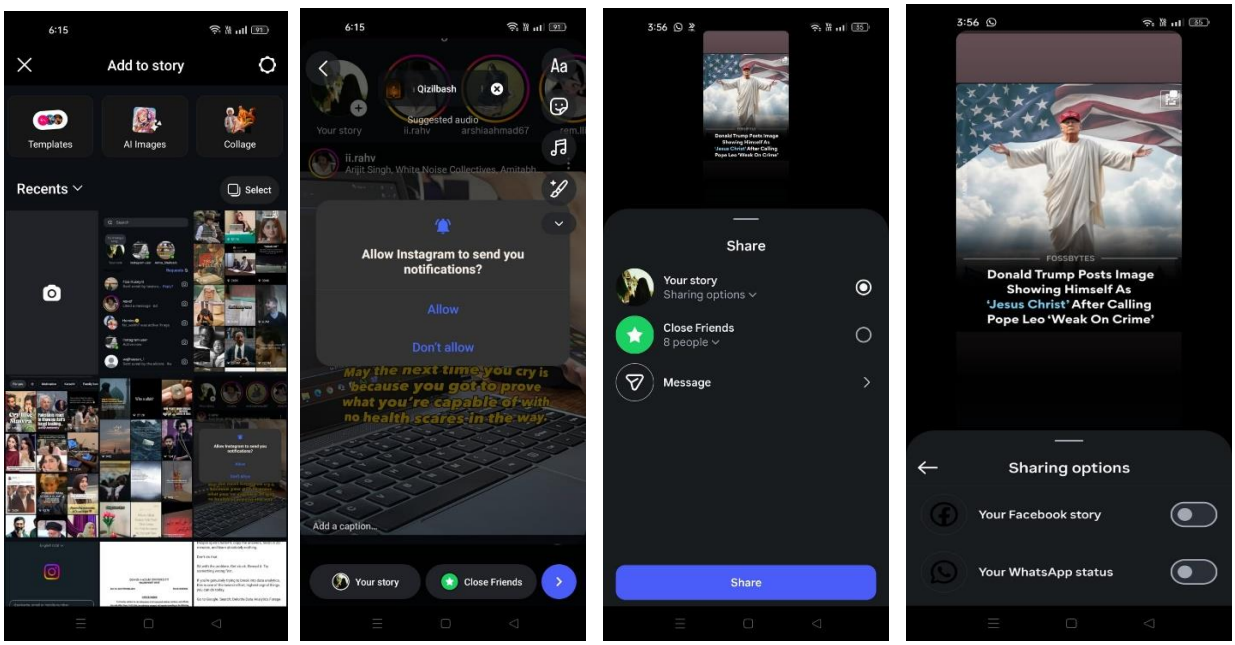


Messaging tab of Instagram with the small bell icon for allowing the notifications

2. Tunneling:

The user is guided step by step for creating account, logged in or creating the story etc.

For story creation, while tunneling the process the Instagram could easily persuade the user to share the story with friends and other platforms like Facebook and WhatsApp etc. through which Instagram persuade the users on other platforms for using the Instagram application.

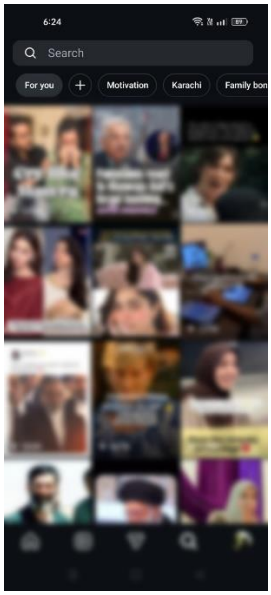


The above screens appeared one after another while guiding the user to create a story with the last screen displaying options of sharing the Instagram story to WhatsApp status or Facebook story.

3.Tailoring

The trending tab of Instagram where a lot of reels, posts are tailored on user's feed according to her/his interests.

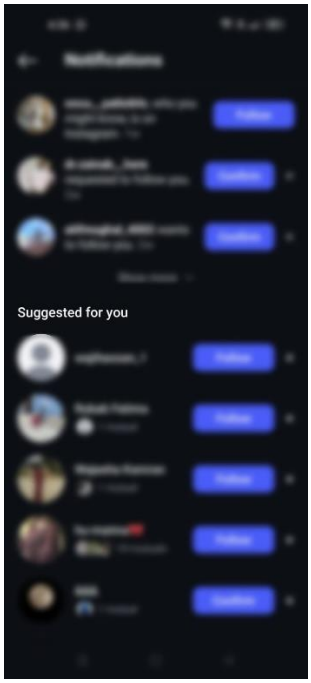
With categories mentioned above the user could have their trending tab feed more tailored to her/her interests.



The trending tab with the categories in the upper ribbon such as Motivation, Karachi etc.

4. Suggestions

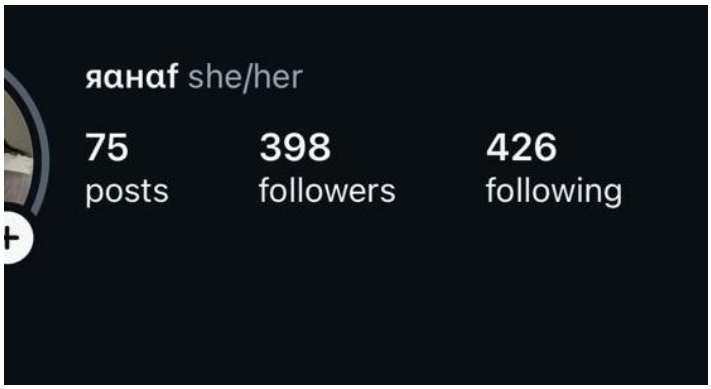
Instagram's suggestions for making other people follow i.e. Suggested section which is tailored based on the user's contact information and the user's already friends' friends are suggested in this tab to persuade them to have more people connected to them which directly strengthens the Instagram user's community.



The Notification tab with "Suggested for you" section.

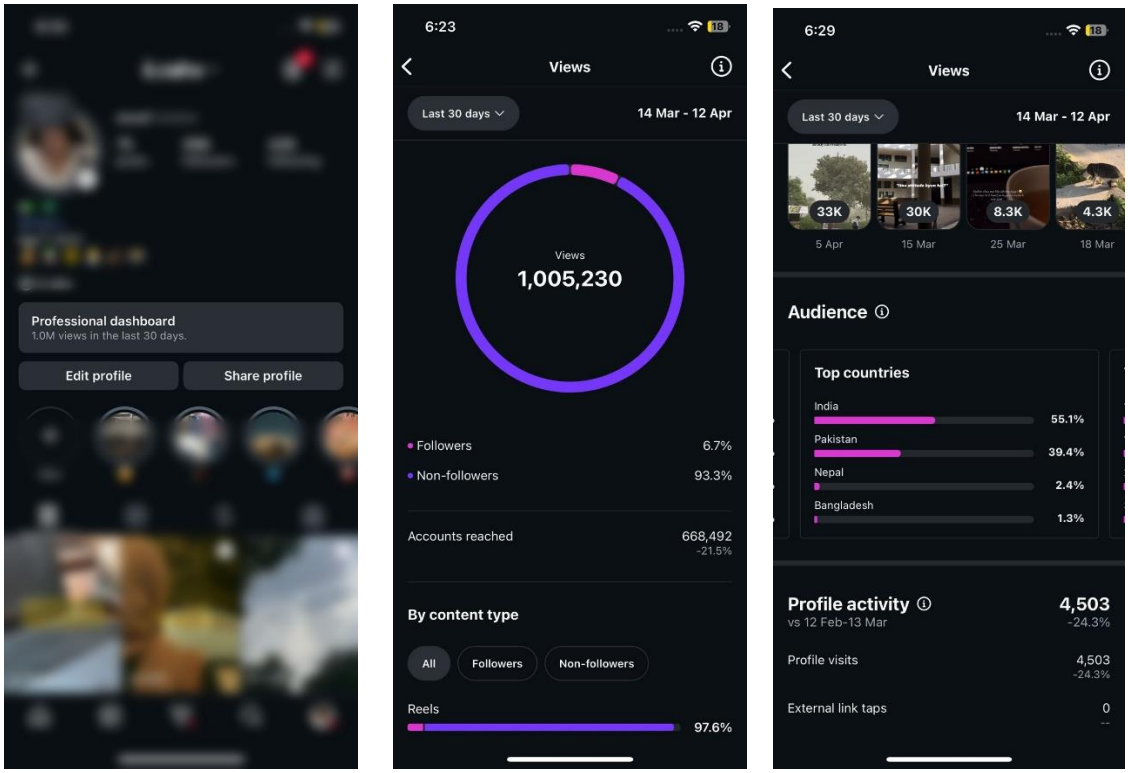
5. Self-Monitoring

The Instagram typically shows the counts of followers, following in the profile section that are self-monitored by the application for the user which persuades them to have more followers or following sometimes.

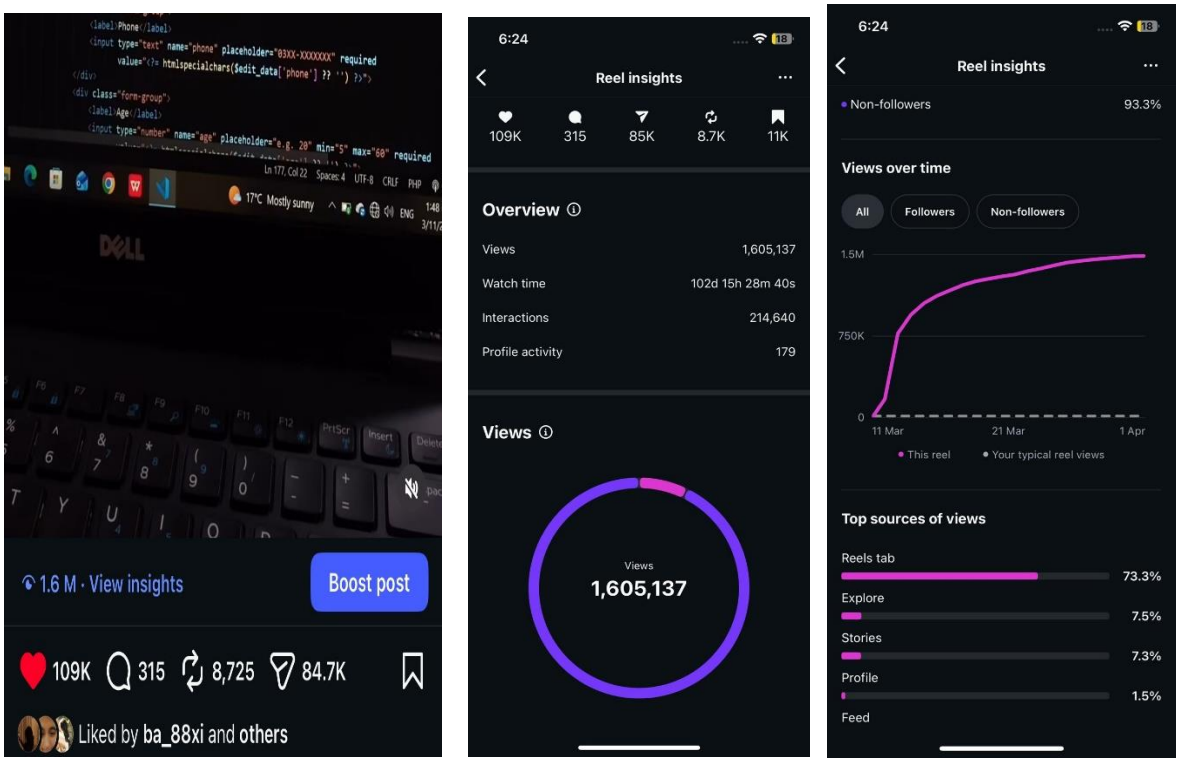


The Profile section with details of followers and following.

If the user is into content creation, then the Instagram provided an option in **"Edit profile"** section for turning into a professional account for which the Instagram provides statistics for every uploaded reel/photo related to reach, likes etc. and for the overall profile too.



The Professional account's professional dashboard with statistics related to content posted on Instagram.



The feature provided for professional accounts by Instagram to have insights related to the specific post.

6. Surveillance

Instagram uses automated algorithms and AI systems to constantly monitor:

- Posts
- Comments
- Captions
- Hashtags
- Direct messages
- Shared videos/images

This monitoring is done to detect:

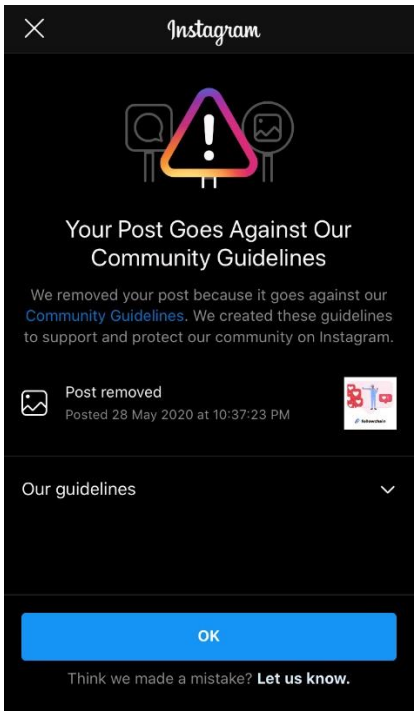
- Hate speech
- Harassment
- Graphic violence
- Misinformation
- Political/extremist content
- Sensitive geopolitical content (e.g. Palestine/Israel conflict-related posts in some moderation debates)

How This Fits Surveillance as Persuasive Technology

If someone uploads potentially abusive or violent content, Instagram's algorithm scans it automatically and if content is flagged then

- posts may be removed
- accounts may receive warnings
- visibility may be reduced (shadow banning)
- temporary/permanent bans may occur.

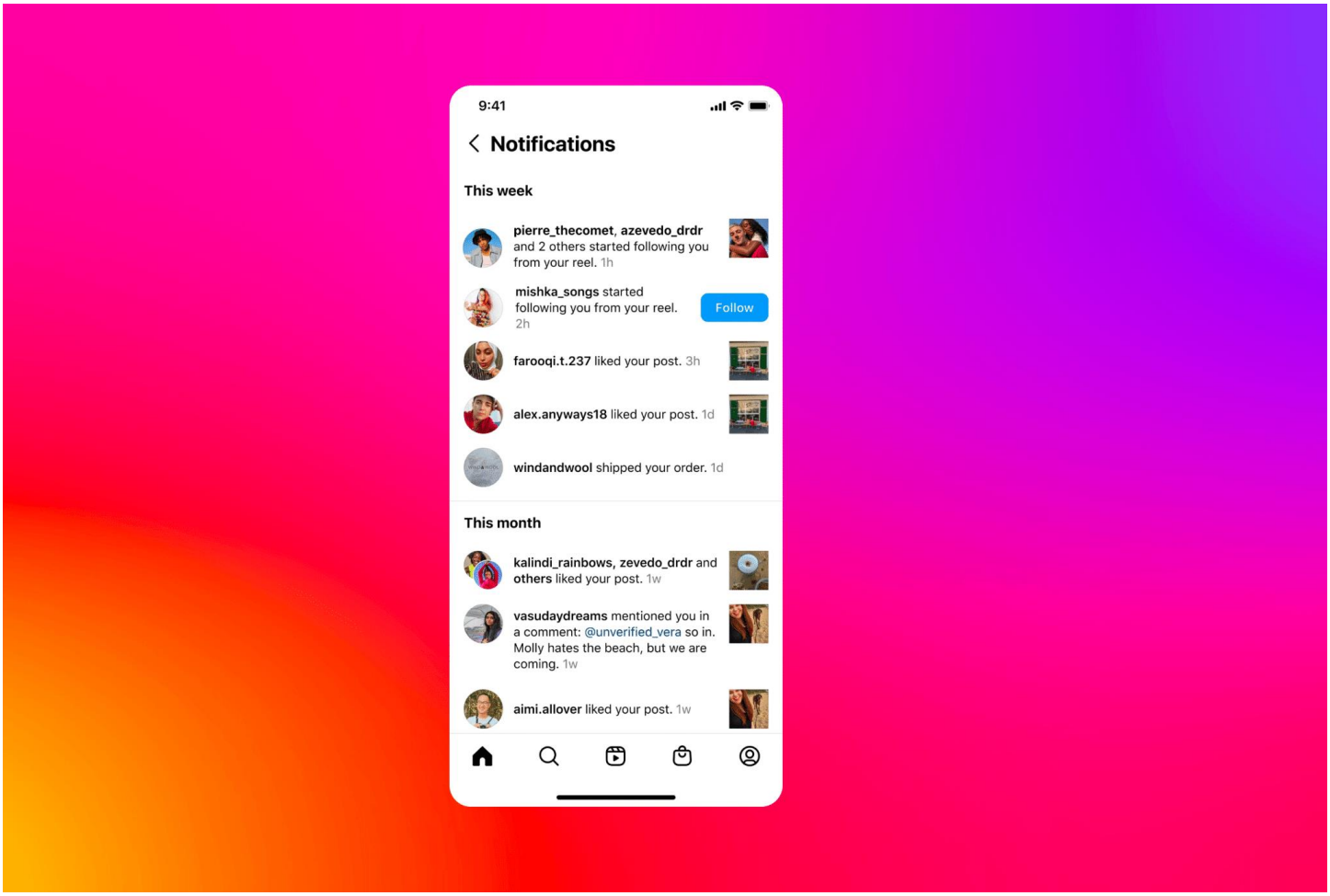
This persuades users to avoid posting prohibited/sensitive material.



Instagram's warning for some post that may violate the community guidelines listed above.

7. Conditioning:

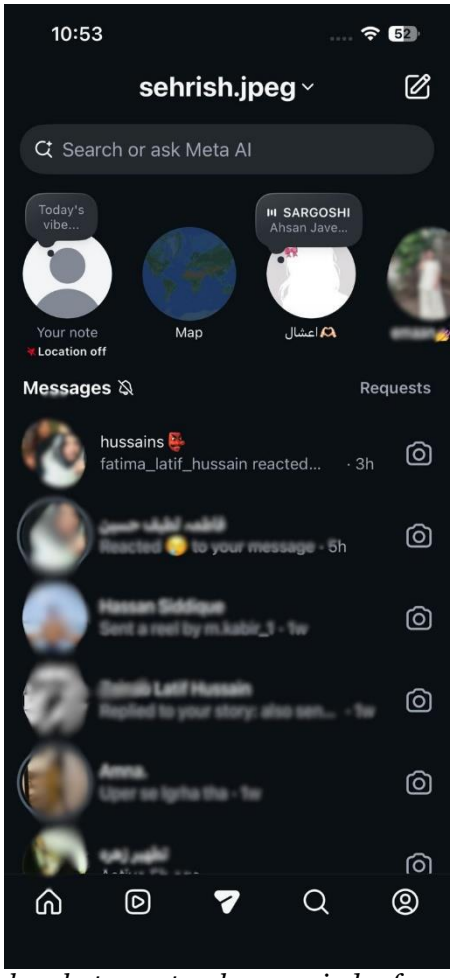
Instagram uses notifications about comments, likes, and other engagement statistics as rewards that encourage users to repeatedly open the app. These positive reinforcements persuade users to check Instagram more frequently which in turn increases the overall app usage.



The notification section of Instagram with notifications related to engagement of the people on the posted content.

Suggestions related to Instagram's current interface:

1. In Instagrams messaging section there is no feature to engage people in messaging chats or groups, no matter how long it has been interacted with the last person Instagram does not remind you, it shows them like normal chats.



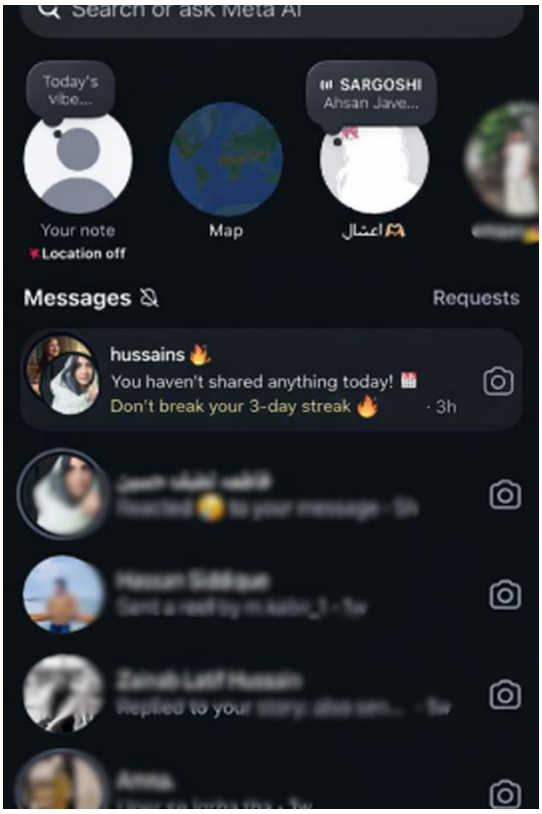
In the image you can see it is regular chat , no streak or reminder for user to interact in chat.

Solution :

There should be streak system ,user should be reminded that you haven't interreacted in the chat in certain time(typically within 24 hour) so that it persuades user to use messaging feature regularly.

Persuasive strategy applied in Solution:

- Self-Monitoring (The streak stats are self-monitored by Instagram).
- Conditioning (The add up in streak counts acts as positive reinforcement for engaging in chatting).



Here it shows that there should be streak that reminds user he/she haven't interacted in chat in a while.

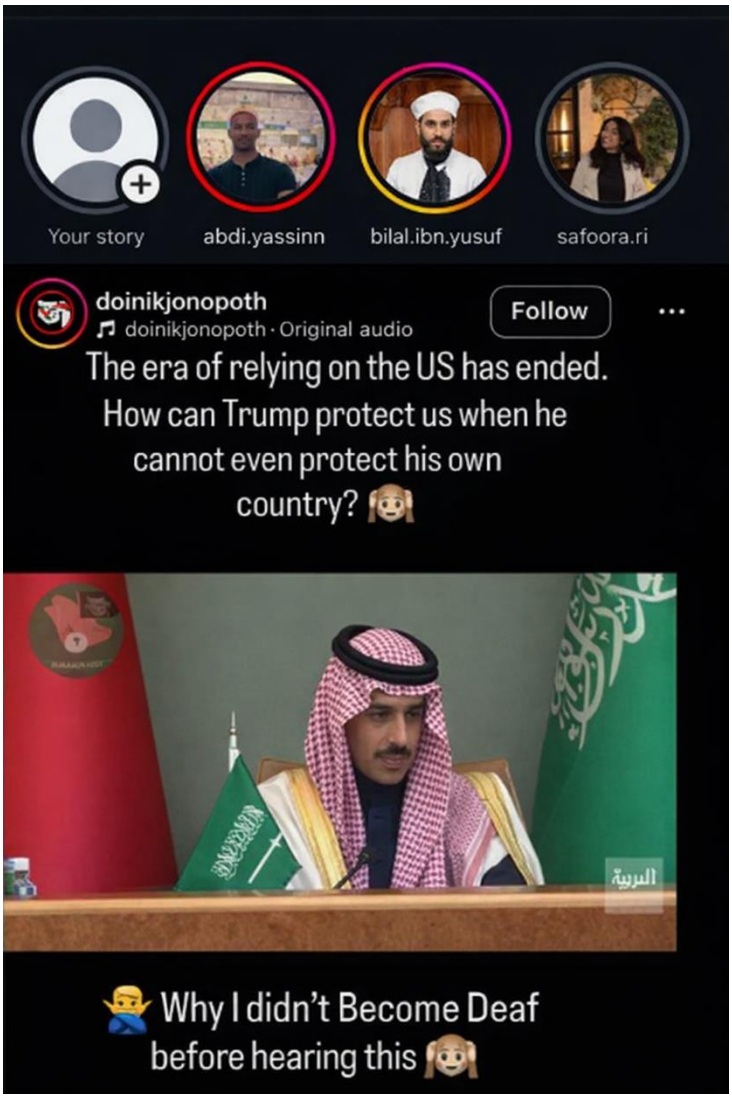
2. In Instagram, users share story (it is like status in WhatsApp), there is no feature in in Instagram that invokes user to see the stories of other users before timeline(typically 24 hours) end and they got disappeared.



This image shows that in regular Instagram it shows story with profile picture with normal colorful circle around it

Solution :

To solve this there should be circle around the profile of person that have uploaded the story to invoke the user to see story before it ends , the circle turned out to red (for example after 12 hours or 6 hours before its timeline ends of 2 hours) so that user understands it is going to end and invoke him to open and engage in it.



This image shows that the story that is going to end should be red .

Persuasive strategy applied in Solution:

- Self-Monitoring (The story timeline is self-monitored by Instagram).
- Suggestion (The red circle indicator as a suggestion to watch the story whose timeline is near to end.)